cultural. Only nationalist organisations like the RSS brought Lachit Borphukan [commander of an indigenous Ahom army that defeated an invading Mughal army in the Battle of Saraighat in 1671] and Rani Ma Gaidinliu in the limelight by giving them the due recognition in the national discourse. Taking this process forward rest of Bharat should completely break the colonial shackles about our geography and nationhood.'[133]

The RSS demand to award India's highest honour, the Bharat Ratna, to the late Rani Gaidinliu of Nagaland is meant to embody both its belief in preserving the animist cultures of the tribes from Christian conversion and its nationalist messaging. The demand was first made by ABVKA in 2014. Rani Gaidinliu had spent fourteen years in British jails, opposed Naga secessionist movements after Independence and fought for the preservation of traditional Naga animist beliefs.[134] As a seventeen-year-old, she had raised a three-tribe Zeliangrong army against the British to establish Naga Raj and resist Naga conversions to Christianity. She lost the Battle of Hangrum (Assam) in 1932. As Rahul Karmakar has pointed out, 'Naga converts were primarily held responsible for her capture and imprisonment until 1947.' Interestingly, Jawaharlal Nehru met her while she was incarcerated in Shillong jail and gave her the sobriquet of Rani (queen), and she became Nehru's 'poster girl' of the Northeast after Independence.[135] The Heraka movement she headed was a minority among the Nagas, but it was strongly opposed to Christian conversion, just as the Sangh was. Masoyo Hunphun Awungashi has shown that, since the 1970s, the 'RSS has backed the Zeliangrong Heraka Association, which sought to reconvert Christian members of the Zeme, Liangmai and Rongmei tribes'.[136]

To understand why a primary driver of the RSS's expansion in the Northeast is its resistance to Christian missionary expansion, we must look at the patterns of religious change in the region. While Christians make up 16.94 per cent of the population, they are primarily concentrated in the hill states. If you take out Assam and Tripura, Census data shows that Christians make up as much as 68.42 per cent of the population in the Northeast. The Christianisation of the hill states—Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland